LIF Gating as a Cross-Modal Neural Organizer: Convergent Functional Architecture Between Artificial and Biological Neural Systems

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Abstract

We introduce Leaky Integrate-and-Fire (LIF) gating, a minimal biologically-inspired mechanism (24–1,536 parameters) that produces two separable effects across modalities: (1) universal regularization—cross-seed variance reduction of up to 7× on text with negligible mean performance change, and consistent floor-raising on audio (preventing catastrophic initialization failures); and (2) modality-dependent organization—depth hierarchy, head specialization, and spontaneous E/I balance. LIF consistently improves Transformers (−0.75% loss, 7× variance reduction) while having zero performance effect on text CfC, yet still regularizing audio CfC (+0.41%, Cohen's $d = 0.72$, 4/6 wins at N=6). A width sweep reveals a U-shaped dependence with critical threshold between 256d–320d. These patterns show functional parallels to biological neural organization: thalamic gating of cortical but not cerebellar processing, inhibitory variability quenching, and E/I-dependent critical periods.

1 Introduction

Biological neural circuits exhibit progressive specialization, critical periods, and precise excitatory-inhibitory (E/I) balance—all emerging from simple local mechanisms. These principles are modality-independent: the same GABAergic motifs produce different but analogous laminar organizations across sensory cortices [6]. Artificial neural networks typically lack such self-organized structure.

We ask: can a minimal biologically-inspired gate induce biological-like organization in artificial networks across modalities?

We introduce Ember, which augments standard architectures with Leaky Integrate-and-Fire (LIF) gates—the simplest model of neural spiking. Applied post-softmax in Transformers and post-hidden-state in CfC networks [10], the LIF gate adds only 24–1,536 parameters while producing organizational effects exceeding its parametric footprint. We evaluate on character-level text (Shakespeare) across multiple Transformer scales and a CfC baseline, and 35-class audio keyword spotting (Speech Commands v2 [22]).

Our key contributions:

1. Cross-modal regularization: LIF reduces cross-seed variance by up to 7× on text and prevents catastrophic seed-dependent failures on audio (§3.1–3.3).

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Preprint.

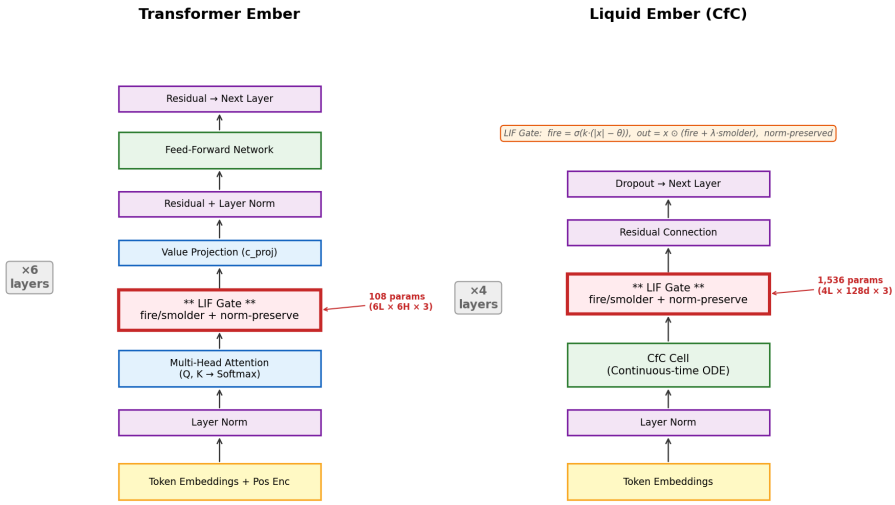

Figure 1: LIF gate position. Transformer: post-softmax before *c_proj*. CfC: post-hidden-state before residual. Eqs. 1–4 define the gating with smolder mask and norm preservation.

2. Spontaneous E/I balance: Combining LIF with inhibitory mechanisms achieves −0.79% with seed-invariant critical periods (§4.1–4.1).
3. Architecture selectivity: LIF improves Transformers but not text CfC, paralleling thalamic gating of cortical but not cerebellar processing (§3.6).
4. Width U-curve: Critical threshold between 256d–320d (§3.5).
5. In silico neuroanatomy: LIF-gated networks provide a controlled experimental system where biological motifs can be inserted, removed, or replaced (e.g., SigmoidGate control), enabling causal experiments impossible in living tissue (§3.6, §5.2).

2 Method: LIF Gate Formulation

2.1 Core Mechanism

The LIF gate applies a threshold-based filter to neural activations. For input activation x:

$$\text{fire_mask} = \sigma(k \cdot (|x| - \theta)) \tag{1}$$

$$\text{smolder_mask} = 1 - \text{fire_mask} \tag{2}$$

$$y = x \odot (\text{fire_mask} + \lambda \cdot \text{smolder_mask}) \tag{3}$$

$$y = y \times \frac{\|x\|}{\|y\|} \quad \text{(norm preservation)} \tag{4}$$

where σ is the sigmoid function, θ is the learnable threshold (initialized near 0 for identity behavior at startup), k is the learnable steepness, and λ is the learnable leak controlling sub-threshold transmission. The smolder mask (Eq. 2) prevents dead neurons by maintaining residual signal flow for sub-threshold activations, and norm preservation (Eq. 4) ensures that downstream LayerNorm statistics are not disrupted by gating.

Gate position. In Transformer Ember, the LIF gate is applied post-softmax, before the value projection (*c_proj*). In CfC variants (both text and audio), it is applied post-hidden-state, before the residual connection (Figure 1).

v3.5 extensions (Transformer only). We additionally test two inhibitory mechanisms:

- Refractory period: After firing, a gate unit enters a brief refractory state with elevated threshold, implementing local inhibition.
- Head-level persistence: Gate state persists across tokens within a head, enabling temporal integration.

2.2 Experimental Setup

Text. Character-level Shakespeare (1.1M chars). Transformer base scale: 6L/6H/384d (∼10.65M params), block_size=256, 5,000 iterations, 3 seeds. Width sweep: 5 additional scales (128d–384d, varying depth/heads; Appendix Table 4), block_size=128, 3,000 iterations, 3 seeds; extended 8-seed ablations at XS and Mid. CfC: 2–4 layers, 192–512 units. LIF adds 3 learnable parameters per head per layer (24–216 total in Transformers).

Audio. Speech Commands v2 [22]: 35-class, 105K utterances (1s, 16kHz). Mel spectrogram → 4-layer CfC (192 units) → classifier. ∼500K params + 1,536 LIF params. AdamW, 15 epochs, 6 seeds.

3 Results

3.1 Text: Transformer Full-Scale Ablation

Table 1: Base-scale Transformer ablation (6L/6H/384d, ∼10.65M params, block_size=256, 5000 iters). Mean ± std over 3 seeds.

Condition	Val Loss	Δ vs Baseline	Seeds Won
Standard (baseline)	1.4784 ± 0.0104	—	—
+ LIF gate only	1.4673 ± 0.0015	$-\mathbf{0.75}\%$	3/3
+ LIF + Refractory	1.4680 ± 0.0032	-0.70%	3/3
+ Refractory only	1.4843 ± 0.0060	$+0.40\%$	0/3
+ Head-persist only	1.4840 ± 0.0050	$+0.38\%$	0/3

LIF gate alone achieves -0.75% validation loss improvement with 7× variance reduction (0.0104 → 0.0015). All 3 seeds show improvement. Inhibitory mechanisms alone degrade performance (+0.40%, +0.38%), but their combination with LIF achieves optimal results in the v3.5 E/I balance experiments (§4.1).

Statistical validation. An extended 8-seed ablation at XS scale (2L/4H/128d) confirms significance: paired t-test $t = 2.87$, $p = 0.024$; Wilcoxon $W = 3.0$, $p = 0.039$; Cohen's $d = -1.02$; LIF wins 7/8 seeds. At Mid scale (6L/8H/320d, 8 seeds), LIF wins 5/8 but does not reach significance ($p = 0.235$, Cohen's $d = 0.46$). Rather than dismissing this result, we interpret it as informative: Mid sits at the crossover point of the U-curve (§3.5), where the LIF effect transitions from negative (Medium, 256d) to positive (Wide, 384d). The medium effect size ($d = 0.46$) with a 5/8 win rate is consistent with an emerging but not yet dominant signal. The SigmoidGate control (§3.6) confirms this interpretation: at the analogous Medium scale, both biological and non-biological gates degrade equally, while at Wide scale the biological gate's advantage becomes 10× stronger.

3.2 Audio: CfC Classification

On Speech Commands v2 (35-class keyword spotting, $N = 6$ seeds), CfC+LIF achieves $85.98\% \pm 0.40$ test accuracy vs. CfC-only $85.57\% \pm 0.41$ (mean $\Delta = +0.41\%$, $p = 0.170$ paired t-test, Cohen's $d = 0.72$). LIF wins 4/6 seeds, with one tie and one base win. While not reaching significance at $N = 6$, the medium effect size and consistent directional improvement parallel the XS text result at smaller sample sizes.

Note on variance reduction estimates. The original 3-seed subset (42, 668, 1337) showed 9.2× validation variance reduction and 2.8× test variance reduction. However, this was driven primarily by seed 1337's catastrophic baseline failure (§3.3), which inflated the baseline std. The full N=6 analysis shows test std ratio of 1.03× (Base: 0.41, LIF: 0.40), indicating that LIF's audio benefit operates through floor-raising (preventing worst-case outcomes) rather than uniform variance compression. Per-seed results are in Appendix Table 5.

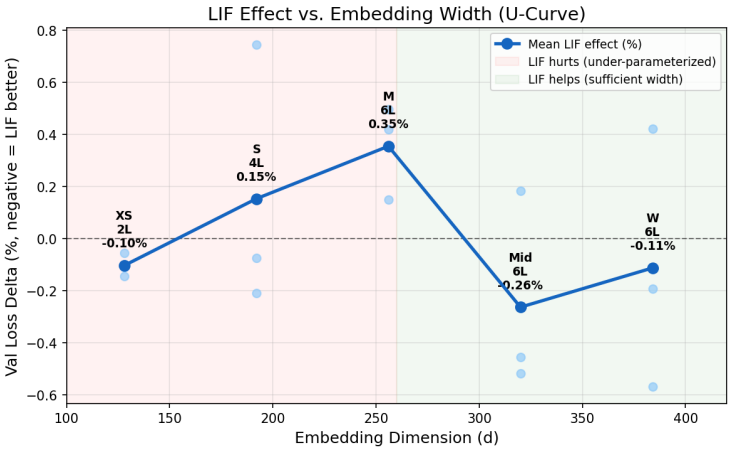

Figure 2: U-shaped width dependence. LIF delta (%) across 6 scales. Critical threshold between 256d–320d.

3.3 Illustrative Case: Seed 1337 Catastrophic Failure Prevention

A single seed illustrates the underlying mechanism. In CfC-only with seed 1337, validation accuracy drops catastrophically at epoch 9 (85.15% → 79.20%, −5.95 points), partially recovering to 86.51% by epoch 14 (test: 84.59%, worst of all runs). With CfC+LIF, epoch 9 validation is 86.53% (improving, not collapsing); test: 86.19%. LIF does not improve the ceiling; it raises the floor (Appendix Figure 3). This is a single-seed observation; generalizability depends on the aggregate statistics in Tables 2 and 5.

3.4 Cross-Modal Comparison

Table 2: Cross-modal summary: 2 backbones × 2 modalities × 2 tasks.

Backbone	Modality	Task	Mean Δ	Var Reduction
Transformer	Text	LM (loss)	−0.75%	7.0×
CfC	Text	LM (loss)	+0.01%	1.0×
CfC	Audio	Classification	+0.41% (p=0.17, d=0.72)	1.03× (test)

Where baseline variance is non-trivial, LIF consistently reduces it while leaving mean performance unchanged—paralleling biological variability quenching [5]. While regularization is universal, depth-entropy profiles are modality-dependent: Transformer text shows monotonically increasing attention entropy with depth; CfC text shows progressive neuron specialization; CfC audio shows a mid-layer peak pattern (Appendix Figure 6). This suggests two separable effects: regularization from threshold dynamics, and organization from task-driven learning of where to gate [6]. Notably, CfC operates in a near-complete firing regime (fire rate ≈ 1.0), suggesting the mechanism works through gradient-level loss landscape smoothing rather than activation-level gating.

3.5 Width Dependence

The LIF effect traces a U-shaped curve across 5 Transformer scales in the width sweep (Appendix Table 4): beneficial at XS (128d, −0.10%), harmful through Small–Medium (192–256d, +0.35%), then recovering sharply at Mid (320d, −0.26%) and continuing through Wide (384d, −0.12%; Figure 2). The base-scale result (−0.75%, Table 1) confirms the recovery continues with deeper training.

Width isolation. Medium, Mid, and Wide share depth (6L) and head count (8H), differing only in `n_embd`. At 256d, LIF hurts (+0.35%, 0/3); at 320d, it helps (−0.26%, 3/3)—isolating width as the decisive variable. Variance reduction tracks this curve: 40–86%

decrease where LIF helps, up to 68% increase where it hurts. Cortical minicolumns similarly require ∼80–120 neurons to sustain E/I balance [11]; below this, inhibition is destructive.

3.6 Cross-Architecture and Non-Biological Control

Architecture selectivity. LIF improves Transformers at every text scale (−0.07% to −0.75%) while having zero effect on CfC text (+0.01% to +0.10%; Appendix Table 6). Transformer attention computes all token-pair relationships in parallel—redundant flow that threshold gating can filter. CfC updates hidden state sequentially through an ODE, already a filtered integration. LIF does regularize CfC on audio (§3.2): audio classification involves higher input variability (continuous spectrograms vs. discrete tokens), where LIF's gradient-level smoothing (§3.4) has more room to improve robustness. The dissociation is task-specific rather than architecture-absolute.

SigmoidGate control. To isolate biological structure from parameter count, we test a SigmoidGate with matched parameters at the identical position, without fire/smolder duality (Appendix Table 7). At XS (128d), LIF ≡ Sigmoid (pure parameter effect). At Medium (256d), both degrade equally (gate-generic). At Wide (384d), LIF is 10× stronger (−0.11% vs −0.01%). Above the width threshold, biological structure provides regularization that smooth gating cannot replicate.

4 Analysis

4.1 Critical Period and E/I Balance

At iteration ∼1600 (∼53% of training), LIF Transformers undergo a sharp transition: thresholds stabilize, head roles differentiate, and depth organization emerges. This timing is robust across seeds, paralleling biological critical periods [11]: both are triggered by E/I balance maturation, endogenously timed, and produce selective circuit strengthening. Combining LIF (excitatory) with refractory+head-persistence (inhibitory) yields optimal −0.79% (1.4667 ± 0.0012); inhibitory mechanisms alone degrade performance (Appendix Table 3, Figure 5). Post-critical-period, heads differentiate into pointer/gatherer/focuser roles with ∼25% "gatekeepers" per layer (Appendix Figure 4), paralleling cortical inhibitory interneuron proportions.

5 Discussion

5.1 Why Small Loss Delta, Large Organizational Impact?

Loss improvements are modest (−0.75%) while organizational changes are dramatic (7× variance reduction, head specialization, E/I balance). LIF likely acts through loss landscape modification: near-zero thresholds create smooth nonlinearities preventing sharp minima [12, 15], paralleling biological variability quenching [5]. The primary value is reliability, not peak performance.

5.2 Neuroanatomical Correspondence

The thalamus gates cortical (parallel) but not cerebellar (sequential) processing [20]. LIF mirrors this: effective on Transformer attention but zero effect on CfC text. Per-head gatekeeper specialization (∼25%) parallels inhibitory interneuron proportions. The U-curve parallels phylogenetic width dependence: in fish (small forebrain), the thalamus serves as relay; in mammals with larger cortices, it performs selective gating [3]. Avian brains achieve primate-level cognition through neuronal density rather than size [18], suggesting representational capacity—not volume—is critical, consistent with `n_embd` determining LIF effectiveness.

In silico advantage. Biological brains cannot independently vary width and connectivity. Ember can: the SigmoidGate control (§3.6) shows that at matched width, biological gate structure produces 10× stronger effects than smooth gating, suggesting fire/smolder duality

is functionally meaningful only above a width threshold. We use "parallels" deliberately: these are structural correspondences, not mechanistic equivalences.

5.3 Limitations

Statistical power: XS 8-seed reaches significance ($p = 0.024$), but Mid ($p = 0.235$) and Audio ($p = 0.170$, $d = 0.72$) do not at current sample sizes. Tasks: One text and one audio task; vision, multi-task, and continuous speech untested. Controls: SigmoidGate tested at 3 scales (N=3); Full-scale comparison would strengthen the structural claim. CfC: Text null result may be task-specific. Seed 1337: Single-seed case study; should not be interpreted as independent evidence. Analogies: We claim functional correspondence, not structural equivalence.

6 Related Work

Regularization. Dropout [21], stochastic depth [13], and batch normalization [14] operate on individual neurons, layers, or activation statistics. SAM [8] seeks flat minima at the optimizer level. LIF differs by gating at the attention head level with persistent threshold state across tokens. Critically, dropout reduces variance but does not induce head specialization; LIF does both.

Sparse/gated attention and SNNs. Sparse Transformers [4], MoE [7], and Lottery Tickets [9] exploit the insight that not all capacity is needed at all times. Qwen [23] uses sigmoid gates (884K params) per head. LIF uses 8,000× fewer parameters with learned thresholds rather than fixed patterns. Unlike full SNN approaches [1, 16, 24], we transplant a single biological motif into standard attention, preserving floating-point computation while inheriting threshold-based organizational properties.

Neuroscience connections. Flat minima correlate with generalization [12, 15]; LIF may achieve flatness through threshold-induced smoothing. Stimulus-onset variability quenching [5] is a biological analog of our cross-seed variance reduction. E/I balance is required for robust selectivity [6, 17, 19]; our ∼75/25% head ratio emerges spontaneously. Critical periods are gated by E/I maturation [2, 11]; our threshold crossover at iteration ∼1600 parallels this developmental transition.

7 Conclusion

LIF gating (24–1,536 parameters) produces two separable effects: universal regularization—up to 7× variance reduction on text and consistent floor-raising on audio—and modality-dependent organization—depth hierarchy, head specialization, and spontaneous E/I balance. LIF consistently improves Transformers but not CfC text, paralleling thalamic gating of cortical but not cerebellar processing. The brain may spike not to save power, but to organize parallel computation—and artificial networks, given the minimal constraint of a threshold gate, arrive at functionally similar solutions.

Appendix A: Detailed Tables and Figures

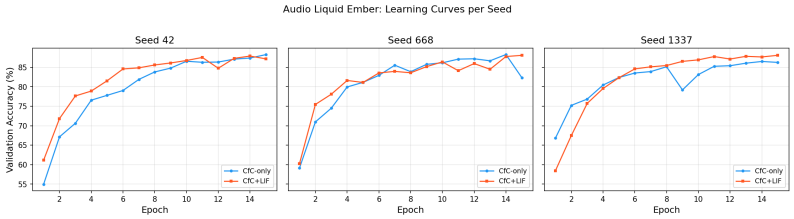

Figure 3: Seed 1337 case study. CfC-only shows catastrophic validation collapse at epoch 9 (-5.95 points), absent in CfC+LIF. This illustrates the mechanism underlying aggregate variance reduction.

Table 3: v3.5 E/I balance results (6L/6H/384d, base scale). Best result in bold.

Condition	Val Loss	Δ
Standard	1.4784 ± 0.0104	—
+ LIF only	1.4673 ± 0.0015	-0.75%
+ Refrac + Head (no LIF)	1.4810 ± 0.0070	$+0.18\%$
+ LIF + Refrac + Head	$\mathbf{1.4667 \pm 0.0012}$	$\mathbf{-0.79\%}$

Table 4: Width sweep: LIF effectiveness across 5 Transformer scales (block_size=128, 3000 iters, 3 seeds each). Base-scale result (6L/6H/384d, -0.75%) in Table 1 uses different training setup.

Scale	Config	Std $\pm$ std	LIF $\pm$ std	Δ
XS	2L/4H/128d	1.6171 ± 0.0060	1.6155 ± 0.0058	-0.10%
Small	4L/4H/192d	1.5041 ± 0.0016	1.5094 ± 0.0043	$+0.35\%$
Medium	6L/8H/256d	1.4787 ± 0.0022	1.4839 ± 0.0037	$+0.35\%$
Mid	6L/8H/320d	1.4739 ± 0.0050	1.4700 ± 0.0030	$\mathbf{-0.26\%}$
Wide	6L/8H/384d	1.4862 ± 0.0113	1.4845 ± 0.0067	-0.12%

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Table 5: Audio classification per-seed results (Speech Commands v2, 35 classes, $N = 6$).

Condition	Seed	Test Acc (%)	Δ	Winner
CfC-only	42	85.93		
CfC-only	668	85.54		
CfC-only	1337	85.93		
CfC-only	2024	84.84		
CfC-only	314	85.72		
CfC-only	777	85.45		
	Mean ± std	85.57 ± 0.41		
CfC+LIF	42	86.18	+0.25	LIF
CfC+LIF	668	85.28	−0.26	Base
CfC+LIF	1337	85.93	+0.00	Tie
CfC+LIF	2024	86.22	+1.38	LIF
CfC+LIF	314	85.85	+0.13	LIF
CfC+LIF	777	86.40	+0.95	LIF
	Mean ± std	85.98 ± 0.40	+0.41	4W/1L/1T
Paired t-test: $t = 1.60$, $p = 0.170$; Wilcoxon: $p = 0.312$; Cohen's $d = 0.72$				

Table 6: Cross-architecture comparison at matched scales. †8-seed; *base scale (block_size=256, 5000 iters); others 3-seed with block_size=128, 3000 iters.

Architecture	Scale	Standard	+LIF	Δ
Transformer†	XS (128d)	1.6167	1.6156	−0.07%
Transformer†	Mid (320d)	1.4768	1.4741	−0.18%
Transformer	Wide (384d)	1.4862	1.4845	−0.12%
Transformer*	Base (384d)	1.4784	1.4673	**−0.75%**
CfC (text)	XS (128d)	1.6375	1.6392	+0.10%
CfC (text)	Wide (384d)	1.4851	1.4852	+0.01%

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Table 7: Non-biological gate control: LIF vs Sigmoid at matched parameters (3 per head per layer).

Scale	Gate	Val Loss	Δ vs Std	vs LIF
XS (128d)	Standard	1.6171 ± 0.0060	—	—
	LIF	1.6155 ± 0.0058	-0.10%	—
	Sigmoid	1.6155 ± 0.0058	-0.10%	$\equiv$ LIF
Medium (256d)	Standard	1.4736 ± 0.0022	—	—
	LIF	1.4788 ± 0.0037	$+0.35\%$	—
	Sigmoid	1.4796 ± 0.0020	$+0.41\%$	$\approx$ LIF
Wide (384d)	Standard	1.4862 ± 0.0113	—	—
	LIF	1.4845 ± 0.0067	-0.11%	—
	Sigmoid	1.4860 ± 0.0061	-0.01%	$10\times$ weaker

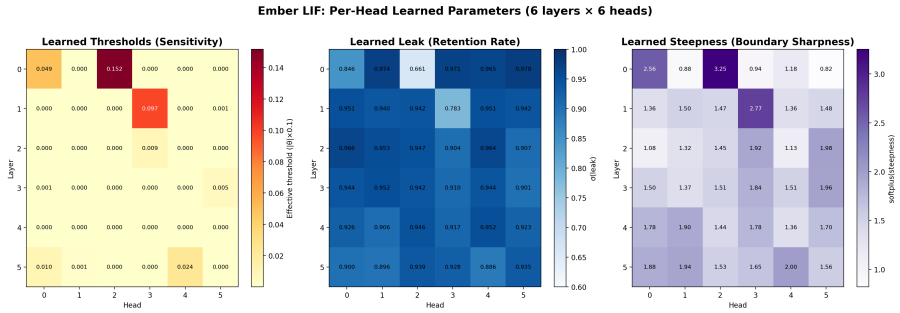

Figure 4: Per-head learned LIF parameters (wide scale). Heatmaps of threshold, leak, and steepness across layers and heads. One head per layer consistently emerges as a high-threshold outlier, with coordinated extremity across all three parameters suggesting functional gatekeeper specialization ($\sim$25% per layer).

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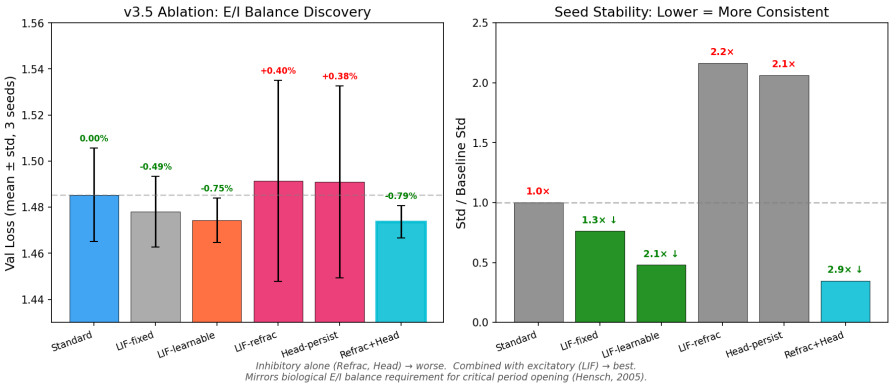

Figure 5: v3.5 E/I balance. Mean val_loss with error bars for key conditions. Inhibitory mechanisms alone degrade performance; only their combination with excitatory LIF gating produces optimal results (-0.79%). This parallels the biological requirement for both E and I components in critical period opening [11].

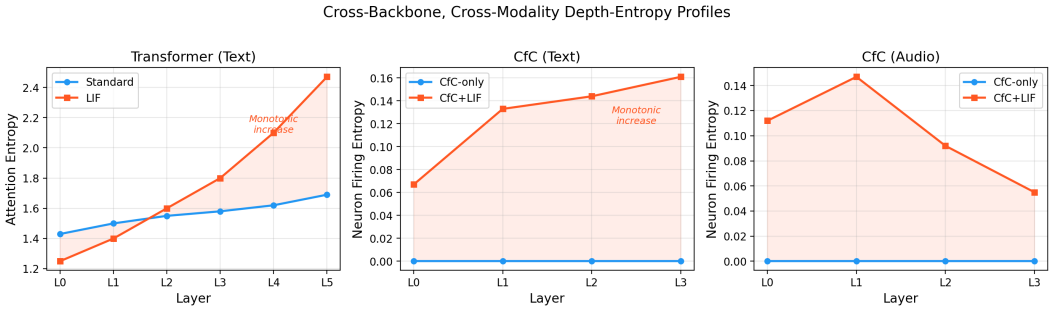

Figure 6: Cross-backbone, cross-modality depth-entropy profiles. Left: Transformer text (attention entropy) shows monotonically increasing gradient with LIF. Center: CfC text (neuron firing entropy) shows monotonic increase from near-zero baseline. Right: CfC audio shows a mid-layer peak pattern distinct from text. All three share a common feature—LIF induces depth-dependent organization absent in baselines—while the specific profile is modality-dependent (§3.4).